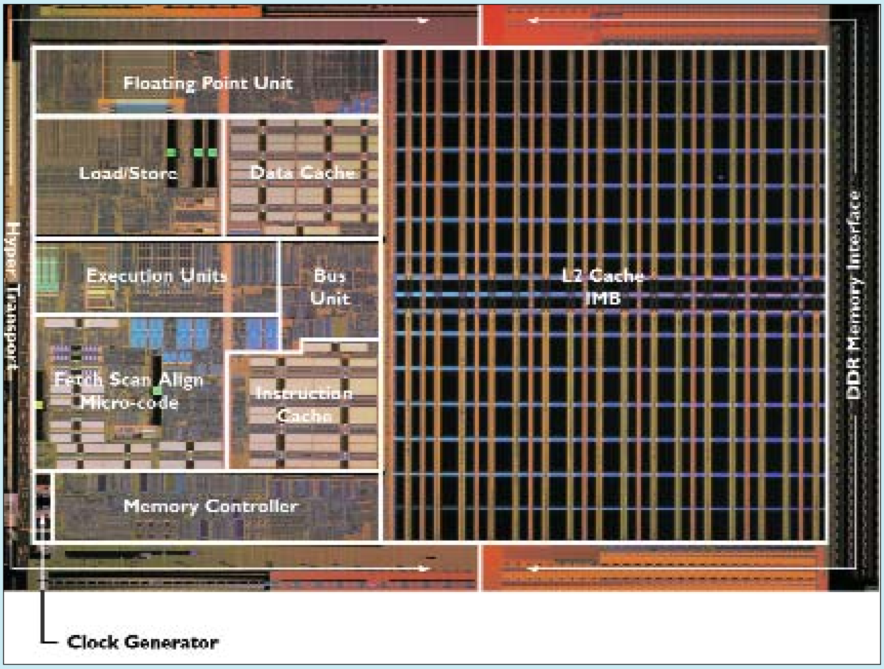

AMD displayed its firm belief in the x86 architecture at the Taipei technology extravaganza. Shown here is its Opteron die that just has a 2 per cent "x86" overhead

Dirk Meyer, Executive Vice President, AMD

> "The **x86 architecture** is the only architecture the world will **ever need**"

tions of time-shifting, scheduled recording of programmes, channel preview, etc.

This unit can sit in your living room, posing as a music system, as the heart of a powerful computer beats within.

Other systems towed VIA, Transmeta or Intel processors. Speaking of AMD-based SFF, meet the IWILL ZMAXdp. This little-behemoth has dual, (that's two!) Opterons, supported by nVidia's nForce 3 chipset. Designed with audio and video professionals in mind, the 64-bit support offered by the AMD Opteron goes a long way in alleviating file-size limits, the mini-rig includes a proprietary form-factor motherboard, dual 3.5-inch hard disk bays, which can be arranged in RAID 0/1/0+1 configurations, and an AGP and a PCI slot. Dear Microsoft; hurry up with the 64-bit Windows XP.

AMD, thus, had reason to be gung-ho about things, as the company's Executive Vice President Dirk Meyer (from the Computation Products Group) firmly planted the x86 flag on IT grounds and spoke of AMD supremacy. "The x86 architecture is the only architecture the world will ever need," he boldly stated, further predicting that AMD64 will be 'the' standard for the convergence wave. He went on to add that IBM's Power architecture will die a lonely death in a few years. The thrust of his statement emerged from a point of view that the x86 ISA is good enough and that the industry does not need anything new. He backed it with a slide showing a microphoto of an Opteron die with real-estate marked out: two per cent of which was marked "x86 overhead" (the ISA), 40 per cent of the land was grabbed by the L2 cache, nine per cent by the Northbridge and HyperTransport, etc. Thus, he said, ISAs do not occupy much space, and the industry ought to leave well-enough alone. Keeping in mind IBM's and Sony's plans to bring the Cell processor (which, hype assures us, can do everything) to PC-like workstations; Meyer's predictions seem all the more interesting.

Info 16th century Portugese sailors called Taiwan Ilha Formosa—the beautiful island. The capital Taipei, where Computex 2004 was held, is built upon a basin that used to be a lake.

The IWILL ZMAXdp is an SFF PC with dual AMD Opteron chips supported by an nForce 3 chipset

Another thing the show brought to the fore was the long-awaited death of legacy standards and ports, and the emergence of technologies that aim to level the playing field. USB, Firewire and SATA are rising stars—especially the first two. PCI Express (PCI-E) is here, and to stay with VIA predicting dominance of the same by next year—bye-bye AGP, your lack of data bandwidth will not b e missed. AMD should be moving to DDR2 in 2005. DirectX 9 has brought a standard API to the table, which everyone—ATi, nVidia, VIA and SIS—can design products to, thus ensuring competition and better products and prices. A word on chipsets: the PT890 will be VIA's first PCI-E chipset for the Intel platform, which will be followed by the K8T890 for AMD processors. Also on the horizon are integrated chipsets from VIA—the K8M890 will feature both DirectX 9 graphics and PCI-E support. Moreover, VIA promises that its mobile chipsets will make a move over to the 0.15 micron process (from the 0.22 micron), will support clock-speed throttling and will draw less power at 1.2 V.

Convergence, small and sleek computers, better standards, healthier competition—these were some of our favourite things that Computex 2004 promised in the months to come.

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